physics to “leak” from large objects since, bit by bit, the quantum weirdness is carried away by the innumerable impinging particles from the environment.

It’s hard to imagine a more satisfying solution to the quantum measurement problem. By being more realistic and abandoning the simplifying assumption that ignores the environment—a simplification that was crucial to making progress during the early development of the field—we would find that quantum mechanics has a built-in solution. Human consciousness, human experimenters, and human observations would no longer play a special role since they (we!) would simply be elements of the environment, like air molecules and photons, which can interact with a given physical system. There would also no longer be a stage one / stage two split between the evolution of the objects and the experimenter who measures them. Everything—observed and observer—would be on an equal footing. Everything—observed and observer—would be subject to precisely the same quantum mechanical law as is set down in Schrödinger’s equation. The act of measurement would no longer be special; it would merely be one specific example of contact with the environment.

Is that it? Does decoherence resolve the quantum measurement problem? Is decoherence responsible for wavefunctions’ closing the door on all but one of the potential outcomes to which they can lead? Some think so. Researchers like Robert Griffiths, of Carnegie Mellon; Roland Omnès, of Orsay; the Nobel laureate Murray Gell-Mann, of the Santa Fe Institute; and Jim Hartle, of the University of California at Santa Barbara, have made great progress and claim that they have developed decoherence into a complete framework (called *decoherent histories*) that solves the measurement problem. Others, like myself, are intrigued but not yet fully convinced. You see, the power of decoherence is that it successfully removes the artificial barrier Bohr erected between large and small physical systems, making everything subject to the same quantum mechanical formulas. This is important progress and I think Bohr would have found it gratifying. Although the unresolved quantum measurement problem never diminished physicists’ ability to reconcile theoretical calculations with experimental data, it did lead Bohr and his colleagues to articulate a quantum mechanical framework with some distinctly awkward features. Many found the framework’s need for fuzzy